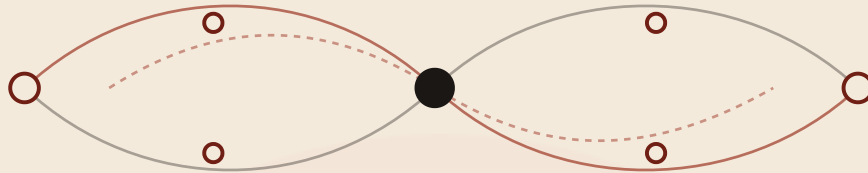


A High-Level View on Work



1. From perception to intention

All work begins, at least in some form, with an idea about something that could be different. Someone observes something in their life or in the reality around them and perceives a possibility, a need, a problem, or a condition worth preserving. From that perception, an objective begins to take shape, and with it an intention to pursue that objective.

The objective does not appear in isolation. Perception is situated. People encounter reality through lenses influenced by their experience, knowledge, biological constitution, social position, and cultural context. These factors do not mechanically determine one conclusion, but they influence what becomes visible, which distinctions seem important, and which possibilities can be imagined.

At first, the objective often appears as a single monolithic whole: formless and with little internal detail or clarity. A person may already intend to pursue it before they can describe the destination precisely. They may know that something should change without yet knowing the work, constraints, or sequence required to change it. The intention is present, but the objective's parts, relationships, and much of its meaning remain implicit.

2. From monolith to compositions

As time and effort are invested, the monolithic objective begins to acquire shape. Distinctions appear inside it: outcomes, constraints, questions, and possible routes. Some of these become objectives in their own right, each with its own scope, while others can take the form of questions to investigate or tasks to perform.

Together, the parts compose the whole rather than sitting beneath it. Each can then be pursued on its own, tied to only part of the initial objective. This composition is not established once and then executed. New parts emerge as work proceeds. Existing parts change meaning, become unnecessary, or reveal dependencies on work elsewhere.

To make any part pursuable, attention has to be bounded around it. A local objective or task carries some of the purpose, assumptions and prior decisions of the larger effort, but never all of them. From this point onward, context refers to these recoverable relationships through which a piece of work remains connected to what explains it.

Within that boundary, the work begins to develop a life of its own. It accumulates decisions, artifacts, and criteria for success. This local autonomy is what makes focused work possible: people can act without continuously reconstructing the entire objective.

This same local autonomy introduces a risk. A piece of work can remain intelligible and internally consistent even as its connection to the larger objective weakens. Nothing within its local boundary necessarily reveals that divergence.

3. When the whole becomes difficult to recover

As work becomes divided, no single part carries the context of the whole. Each part may remain understandable on its own while its relationship to the broader objective becomes harder to see. This context of the whole becomes distributed across tasks and artifacts. The pieces remain, but the relationships that once held them together become more difficult to recover.

The loss can also be difficult to notice. Local work continues to produce visible results. Tasks are completed, documents are written, and decisions are implemented. Each result may appear successful when considered within its own boundary.

But completing the parts is not enough to realize the objective. Their contributions have to come together as the work unfolds. Without that composition, effort can continue without becoming progress, and local success can conceal the failure of the larger effort. The work becomes more precise locally while its purpose becomes less visible globally.

4. A system for work

A system for work would therefore need to keep distinct pieces of work connected to the broader objective and to one another. From an objective, it should be possible to follow the work through which it is being pursued. From a task, it should be possible to return to the purpose, decisions, and conditions that gave it meaning.

These connections could not form a single fixed hierarchy. The same task may contribute to several objectives, depend on work elsewhere, or acquire a significance that was not visible when it began. The system would need to preserve these relationships without forcing them into one definitive arrangement.

It would also need to preserve change. Later understanding may revise an objective, overturn a decision, or reveal that some work no longer contributes to the larger effort. Recoverable continuity would keep the earlier state visible alongside what changed and why.

Such a system could never contain the complete meaning of the work. Some relationships would remain uncertain, disputed, or simply missing. It should make those gaps visible rather than filling them with an invented coherence. The aim would be to make it possible to move through that division without losing sight of the whole.

A system like this would make ordinary questions easier to answer. What work has actually been completed toward this objective? What remains unfinished? What is blocking this task? Which decisions shaped the project, on what evidence, and under whose authority? What changed, and which parts of the work should change with it?

The work would become easier to inspect because the relationships needed to answer these questions would remain recoverable.